



Graphics Cards

The graphics card segment is one which more or less has the same characters and same storyline with a few twists thrown in for good measure. The twists this year were introduction of the PCIe 3.0 interface on the HD 7000 series and GTX 600 series from AMD and NVIDIA respectively. NVIDIA also introduced a new architectural component called the SMX – a glorified stream multiprocessor, a boost clock – which increases GPU clock speed under load. AMD introduced the Graphics Core Next architecture. Both AMD and NVIDIA switched from the 40nm to 28nm manufacturing process.

Zero1 Winner ZOTAC GTX 690

As if the GTX 680 wasn't enough, NVIDIA came out with a GTX 690 which sports two GK104 GPUs and a massive 3072 CUDA cores. Needless to say, this ZOTAC GTX 690 gave the best performance in every benchmark or game we threw at it. And it manages to look great as well, thanks to the metal chassis with a huge fan in the centre. ZOTAC hasn't altered the reference design much and we like it that way. So far as performance goes, there was no equal and it rightfully deserves the Zero1 Award. Its pricing is prohibitive at over 65k, but then, this is not a card for the average user. Till the date of writing this, we had not received the HD 7990 – AMD's dual-GPU answer to the GTX 690.

Worthy Mentions

ASUS HD 7970 Matrix Platinum Edition 3GB

This is an ROG branded GPU and is the best performing AMD card we tested this year. It comes with a massive factory overclock and has headroom for much more. The card comes with a custom PCB as expected with features like VGA Hotwire, Tweak IT, Load Indicator, etc. As far as performance goes, it was still lower than ASUS GTX 680 DC2T, but the HD 7970 still kicks butt. Adding the fact that the overclocking headroom is quite good, this deserves a worthy mention.

ASUS Direct CUII Top GTX 680

This variation of ASUS GTX 680 has a mammoth 4 GB memory and it narrowly raced past the HD 7970 DC2T in terms of performance. This card which is part of the Direct CU II series happens to be overclocked than the stock GTX 680 by 131 MHz. The 7970, also



◀ ZOTAC GTX 690
Price: ₹67,200



ASUS HD 7970
Matrix Platinum
Edition 3GB
Price: ₹36,499



ASUS Direct
CUII TOP
GTX 680
Price: ₹40,500



Sapphire HD
7770 Vapor-X
Price: ₹9,990

from ASUS came second because it's also clocked 75 MHz higher than a stock card. Both cards come with improved coolers consisting of twin fans spread over 6 and 5 heat pipes for the 7970 and 680 respectively. Not to mention the solid design features which include protective metal back plates and twin fans. Without a doubt, it deserves a worthy mention for its prowess in performance as well as design and build.

Mid-Range Worthy Mentions

Sapphire HD 7770 Vapor-X

This factory-overclocked card from Sapphire not only offers a good value for money (at a sub 10k pricing) but it also runs quite cool with maximum load temperature at 56 degrees, which is very good. For those looking at an affordable but decently performing AMD card, this makes for a decent choice.

ZOTAC GTX 650Ti AMP Edition

Not everyone can afford the 25k plus GTX 680s and HD 7970s. So for those who have a limited budget

but want a Kepler GPU, the ZOTAC GTX 650Ti AMP Edition offers a very good choice thanks to its sub-15k pricing. The performance offered is mighty capable of running full HD games with medium to low AA and AF settings.



ZOTAC GTX
650Ti AMP
Edition (2 GB)
Price: ₹12,999